Tino Best produced an inspired spell of fast bowling, testing me on quite a few occasions. It was only later that I learned that it was his son's birthday and he had promised him he would get my wicket as a birthday present. On one occasion when I was beaten, he appealed and I laughed and asked what was wrong with him, because the ball was miles away from my bat! In the next over I could sense that he was about to bowl me a bouncer and I was ready for it. I had all the time in the world to play the upper cut – but I missed it by a few inches. I don't know why I wasn't able to connect with any of the short balls. I finally managed to play a cover drive and as the ball was being retrieved from the boundary, I mock-punched Tino Best and said it was his lucky day because I had missed out on at least four boundaries against him. We are good friends off the field and fierce competitors on it.

I brought up my half-century with a straight drive and raised my bat to my mother. The delighted crowd kept shouting 'Sachinnn Sachinnn' and it was tremendous to be out there. Even when I was not facing the ball, the crowd kept chanting.

About five minutes after the first drinks break, Narsingh Deonarine was given the ball. I was aware that he was an occasional off-spinner who would probably bowl only three or four overs. I told myself that I should do nothing foolish against him but just take a few singles. Only if there was a loose ball should I put it away for a boundary.

The ball I got out to bounced slightly more than I expected. It was a fuller delivery and faster than his normal one. I thought I could cut it to backward point for four. I had played a similar shot against Shillingford a little earlier. It all happened in a flash. Before I knew it, I had played the shot and the ball was on its way to Darren Sammy at slip. It hit his chest and he caught it on the rebound. I was out, for 74, with the score at 221–3.

As I turned to walk to the pavilion, my mind was flooded with thoughts. Why did I have to play that stroke? Why cut the ball when I could have played it to cover for a single or even left it for the keeper? What prompted me to go for the cut shot at all? Throughout my career I have always questioned my shot selection after getting out and it was no different in that innings.

That's when the thought came to me that there might not be another innings. It dawned on me that this could well be the last time I walked off the field as an India batsman. The way the match was going, there